Is college a scam?

Channel: Tim Luong · Published: Oct 14, 2026 · Watch: https://www.youtube.com/shorts/cDUD0-TUnT0 Source: full transcript

📋 Executive Summary

Tim Luong shares a nuanced take on college: great for life experience and self-directed experimentation, but a scam if you pay a quarter million dollars expecting it to define your career path for you.

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🎓 Tim's Personal College Experience 0:00

- Attended **UCLA** and graduated early
- Admits he learned nothing at university that directly helped him succeed in business or added a single dollar to his net worth
- Despite that, describes it as "the greatest time of my life"
  - Went out four nights a week, partied
  - Started businesses on the side — all of them failed, but gained real entrepreneurial experience
  - Had little else demanding his time, so he skipped class and used the freedom to experiment and figure things out
- Key framing: the social, experimental, self-directed side of college is **not** what he'd call a scam

🚨 When College Becomes a Scam 0:21

- The scam, in his view, is a specific expectation: going to university so that the institution tells you what to do with your career and how to make money
- Cites the rise of AI as a reason this is increasingly true — universities can no longer reliably teach you what you'll want to do with your life
- Observes that looking back, **95% of the people around him had no idea what they were doing** — including himself
- Price check on the scam: paying "a quarter million dollars for four years" expecting career direction
  - That sum buys you, more often than not, a path someone else chose for you

🪞 The Copycat Trap: Following Others Instead of Yourself 0:43

- Describes a common psychological pattern among lost students:
  - You look at the peer who gets better grades or seems to "have their life together"
  - You copy their trajectory: if they go to Wall Street, you go to Wall Street; if they pursue medicine, you pursue medicine
- Raises three pointed questions to challenge this behavior:
  - Is that actually what *you* want?
  - Or is it what your *parents* want?
  - Or is it simply what your *peers* are doing?
- Core critique: most students end up either mimicking whoever they perceive as successful, or following the path their parents envisioned for them

> "The university is a scam if you think paying a quarter million dollars for four years is going to tell you what you want to do for work — because usually you just end up copying the person you think is successful."

- Implicit takeaway: use college for experience, experimentation, and freedom — but don't outsource the question of what you want your life to look like to an institution or to social comparison